

the government found that the sense of the House seemed to be against going ahead with the deal in its current form. It also brought to the fore the divisive issue over whether it was the executive or Parliament that had the final say in foreign policy.

The Left started the fight by throwing a hammer into the works, all but destroying the nuclear deal. Manmohan initially seemed to have had the courage of his conviction when he dared CPI(M) strong man Prakash Karat to do his worst and withdraw support to his government. But when the Congress and its allies in the UPA Government realised that the Left may carry out its threat, prudence (many say cowardice) prevailed. Manmohan talked of his not being a "one-issue

Government" and a co-ordination committee was set up with the Left to buy what many saw then as an honourable exit.

The art of blinkmanship, though, had not as yet reached its zenith. Just when all seemed lost, the Left parties inexplicably allowed the Government to proceed with the talks with the IAEA. That, Karat revealed (and subsequently denied), was because they wanted to show a united front to avoid a secular setback in the Gujarat elections. It didn't seem to help. A resounding defeat by the indefatigable Narendra Modi, left the Congress reeling and also the fate of the much-touted deal. CPI(M) politburo member and Rajya Sabha MP, Sitaram Yechury gleefully summed up

STAND OFF

“If this is the issue they want to break up with us on, all political parties need to be prepared for elections any time.”

PRAKASH KARAT
CPI (M) LEADER

“We are not a one-issue Government. If the deal does not come through, it will be disappointing. The deal is not the end of life.”

MANMOHAN SINGH
PRIME MINISTER

COMRADES IN ARMS:
Manmohan with Bush



singular foreign policy triumph, instead descended into a humiliating battle for their rabid anti-Americanism to all but kill the civilian nuclear deal with the US